

26-year-old also made late runs into the box and scored twice in the quarterfinal. With his current club Girona relegated from La Liga, a host of European clubs could look to snap him up at a cut price.

Guarding the sticks

Few teams exceeded expectations quite like Cape Verde. The island nation gave Argentina a run for its money in the round of 32 after holding Spain to a stalemate in the group stage.

The island nation's goalkeeper, Josimar Dias, better known as Vozinha, emerged as one of the tournament's surprise stars. Although the 40-year-old is in the twilight of his career, his status as a free agent following the expiry of his contract with Portuguese second-division side Chaves could yet earn him another move.

Another goalkeeper who impressed between the posts was Paraguay's Orlando Gill. His saves-per-90 figure of 4.3 was the fourth-best in the World Cup. He was also the hero of the penalty shootout as Gustavo Alfaro's side stunned Germany in the first knockout round.

The 6ft 6in goalkeeper currently plays for Argentine Primera Division side San Lorenzo, whom he joined in 2025. At 26, he could earn a move to Europe or, at the very least, to MLS.

His sale could also prove a blessing for the Argentine club, which is battling crippling financial issues.

Zion Suzuki, too, will be in high demand across Europe after his stellar displays for Japan. The 23-year-old USA-born goalkeeper has been Parma's first-choice keeper since his move two years ago. He was linked with Manchester United last summer, and his World Cup performances will only have increased his list of suitors.

Fan favourite

Mexico's run to the knockout stages came with immense backing from its adoring home fans. One of the players who drew the loudest



Standing tall: Japan goalkeeper Zion Suzuki started every match of the team's 2026 World Cup campaign, including the Round-of-32 clash against Brazil. The Parma shot-stopper plays his club football in Italy. GETTY IMAGES

cheers was Roberto Alvarado. The attacking midfielder was one of El Tri's most creative players and finished with three assists.

Deployed on the right wing by Javier Aguirre, he regularly cut inside and whipped crosses in with his favoured left foot. The Guadalajara star has spent his entire club career in Mexico. At 27, this transfer window could represent his best opportunity to make the leap to Europe.

Another winger who impressed with his agility and goal threat was Antonio Nusa. One of Norway's most exciting talents, Nusa was a constant menace on the left wing, repeatedly cutting inside to threaten goal. He showcased his trademark

finish in the round of 32 against Ivory Coast, curling the ball into the far corner.

The 21-year-old, who has often credited Neymar as an influence, could be due a move to a bigger European club after two years at RB Leipzig.

Folarin Balogun, Crysencio Summerville, Manu Kone, Charles De Ketelaere and Tarik Muharemovic are just a few more names on what could be an almost endless list.

Of course, it does not always work out as clubs hope (just ask Manchester United fans about Kleberson), but the World Cup remains a critical audition for players hoping to earn a big move.